

ST 01: Introduction to Theology

Finalized Course Outline (35 Lectures)

Morning Star Regional Seminary, Barrackpore BTh First-Year Course, Academic Year 2026-27

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THE SIX GOALS

By the last day, every student should be able to answer six questions:

1. What is theology?
2. Why do theology?
3. How is theology done?
4. Who has authority in theology?
5. How has theology developed through history?
6. How do I become a responsible theologian today?

The sixth is the destination. It is seeded at Lecture 5 and returns in every unit.

THE SPINE

The four precepts of Lonergan run through the course and give it its shape: be attentive (the sources, Unit III), be intelligent (the history, Unit IV), be reasonable (the method, Unit V), be responsible (Unit VI). The word "responsible" in Goal 6 is the fourth precept. The form of the course is also its goal.

THE RHYTHM OF EACH CLASS (45 minutes)

Ten minutes opening problem, fifteen minutes teaching, ten minutes discussion through the reading rotation, five minutes reflection, five minutes assignment. Three students carry each reading as summariser, critic, and responder. The professor moderates. Every daily reading is eight to twelve pages.

UNIT I — DISCOVERING THEOLOGY

Lectures 1 to 5. Goal served: Why do theology?

This unit opens the course with the existential question, not the dictionary. It asks why a believer must think, how God reaches us, and what it means to receive theology as a calling. Lecture 5 plants Goal 6.

Lecture 1. Can a priest preach without doing theology? Focus: theology as a living process from information to formation to transformation; *theos* and *logos*; the triple claim of Aquinas, taught by God, teaching of God, leading to God. Reading: Manual, pages 1 to 2. In class: opening icebreaker linking regency to the classroom; begin the journal and the glossary.

Lecture 2. If I already believe, why must I understand? Focus: *fides quaerens intellectum* in Anselm; faith seeking understanding as the mean between fideism and rationalism; Augustine and the child at the seashore. Reading: Anselm, *Proslogion* proem; Manual page 1; Ormerod, Chapter 1, pages 3 to 9.

Lecture 3. How does God get through to us? Focus: revelation as the free self-communication of God in deeds and words; revelation received in faith; creation, Exodus, paschal mystery, Church. Reading: *Dei Verbum*, Chapter 1, sections 2 to 6; Manual pages 11 to 12.

Lecture 4. Is faith a leap in the dark or a way of seeing? Focus: faith as personal encounter, not bare assent; faith and reason as two wings; Abraham, Mary, and Jesus as models of faith. Reading: *Fides et Ratio*, sections 1 to 15.

Lecture 5. Is theology a job or a calling? Focus: theology as vocation; the theologian as believer, thinker, listener, servant, prophet; here Goal 6 is seeded. Reading: *Donum Veritatis*, sections 6 to 12; Orientation handout on the theologian. Milestone: assign the Unit I paper, "Why do I want to study theology?", 500 words, due before Lecture 6.

UNIT II — THE NATURE OF THEOLOGY

Lectures 6 to 10. Goal served: What is theology?

This unit defines theology and tests its claims. It moves from the event of Christ to reflection on it, surveys the meanings the word has carried, and draws the line between authentic theology and its corruption.

Lecture 6. Why did Jesus never write a theology book? Focus: theology as reflection on the Christ-event, not the event itself; the move from life to reflection; faith experience as starting point. Reading: Ormerod, Chapter 1, pages 10 to 14; Müller, opening section.

Lecture 7. Has theology always meant the same thing? (Part one) Focus: the biblical, patristic, and scholastic senses of theology, each shaped by its age. Reading: Manual pages 1 to 2 and 5 to 7; Müller, a short section.

Lecture 8. Has theology always meant the same thing? (Part two) Focus: the modern and contemporary senses; the shift in starting point, from revealed truths to experience and context. Reading: Ormerod, Chapter 3, pages 27 to 37.

Lecture 9. Is theology a science? Focus: theology as science, as wisdom, and as prayer; the polarities of mystery and intelligibility, of committed and searching. Reading: Ormerod, Chapter 4, pages 42 to 52. In class: the debate, "Is theology a science?", feeds participation.

Lecture 10. What makes theology true, and not heresy? Focus: the marks of authentic theology, biblical, Trinitarian, ecclesial, liturgical, patristic, ecumenical; the line between theology and its corruption. Reading: Manual page 2, page 4, and page 6.

UNIT III — THE SOURCES OF THEOLOGY

Lectures 11 to 16. Goal served: Who has authority? Precept: be attentive.

This unit asks where theology comes from and who may say what is true. It names Scripture, Tradition, the Magisterium, the *sensus fidelium*, reason, and experience, and shows how Vatican II re-mapped them.

Lecture 11. Why are there hundreds of theologians if truth is one? Focus: plurality is not error; the one and the many; *ekam sat viprah bahudha vadanti*; philosophy and theology in conversation. Reading: Ormerod, Chapter 2, pages 15 to 26.

Lecture 12. Is the Bible enough? Focus: Scripture as the norm that norms all and is normed by none; the soul of theology; the Catholic answer to *sola scriptura*. Reading: *Dei Verbum*, Chapter 3, sections 11 to 13; Manual pages 9 to 11.

Lecture 13. Can the dead vote? Focus: Tradition as the living faith of the dead; the one Tradition through the many traditions; the work of the Spirit. Reading: *Dei Verbum*, Chapter 2, sections 7 to 10; Manual pages 3 to 4.

Lecture 14. Who decides when we disagree? Focus: the Magisterium as servant, not master, of the Word; ordinary and extraordinary teaching; the *sensus fidelium*. Reading: *Lumen Gentium*, section 12; *Donum Veritatis*, sections 13 to 21.

Lecture 15. Can reason and experience be sources too? Focus: reason, lived experience, and the cry of the poor as theological sources; the *anawim*; what the widow knows that the library can miss. Reading: Manual pages 3 to 4; Gutierrez, *A Theology of Liberation*, Chapter 1 opening.

Lecture 16. How did Vatican II re-map the sources? Focus: Scripture and Tradition from one source, meeting at one table of the Word; the end of the old contest between them. Reading: *Dei Verbum*, Chapter 6, sections 21 to 26; Ormerod, Chapter 4, pages 52 to 57. In class: the comparison activity, Matthew 5, the Catechism, *Lumen Gentium*, and a Church Father.

UNIT IV — THE HISTORY OF THEOLOGY

Lectures 17 to 22. Goal served: How has theology developed? Precept: be intelligent.

This unit teaches history not as dates but as the question each age was trying to answer. The Gospel does not change; the questions do.

Lecture 17. Why does every age produce a different theology? Focus: each age writes theology in answer to its own crisis; the development across the periods in one view.

Reading: Manual pages 5 to 8.

Lecture 18. Who is this Jesus? (The Patristic age) Focus: the identity of Christ as the driving question; Nicaea and Chalcedon; the Alexandrian and Antiochene schools; Origen, the Cappadocians, Augustine. Reading: Manual pages 5 to 7; the Nicene Creed with a short word on the Arian controversy.

Lecture 19. Can faith and reason live together? (The Scholastic age) Focus: the union of faith and reason; Anselm, Aquinas, Bonaventure, Scotus, Ockham; the great synthesis.

Reading: Manual page 7; *Fides et Ratio*, sections 43 to 48.

Lecture 20. Who saves, and how? (The Reformation and Trent) Focus: the question of justification; *sola scriptura*, *sola fide*, *sola gratia*; the answer of Trent. Reading: Manual page 8; a short reading on justification.

Lecture 21. How do we believe in a doubting world? (The modern age) Focus: theology before secular doubt; the recovery of Scholastic thought; Marcel on problem and mystery.

Reading: Manual pages 8 to 9; *Gaudium et Spes*, sections 1 to 4.

Lecture 22. What did the Church wake up to? (Vatican II) Focus: *aggiornamento* and *riunione*; the renewed understanding of Church, world, religions, and liturgy; reading the signs of the times. Reading: Manual pages 8 to 9; *Gaudium et Spes*, sections 4 to 10.

UNIT V — THE METHODS OF THEOLOGY

Lectures 23 to 29. Goal served: How is theology done? Precept: be reasonable.

This is the heart of the course. Here students learn that theology is a method, not only information. The unit is built on the six models of Bevens, with the branches named clearly and the contextual streams slotted into the models. Orthodox theology closes the unit with worship and mystery.

Lecture 23. Is theology information or method? Focus: method shapes what one can see; the four pillars of doing theology; the hermeneutic circle of Segundo; the four precepts of Lonergan. Reading: Ormerod, Chapter 4, pages 42 to 57; Segundo on the hermeneutic circle.

Lecture 24. Three ways into one mystery (The branches) Focus: dogmatic, biblical, and historical theology as branches, three approaches to one mystery; the full map of the disciplines. Reading: Manual pages 4 to 5; Müller on the disciplines.

Lecture 25. Models, not chaos (Bevens and the six models) Focus: translation, anthropological, praxis, synthetic, transcendental, countercultural; the streams as models doing one work. Reading: Bevens, *Models of Contextual Theology* (the lecture notes carry a full overview).

Lecture 26. Can the poor produce theology? (The praxis model) Focus: liberation and Dalit theology; the worm view and the bullock cart; Jesus identified with the crushed; Nirmal. Reading: Nirmal, the founding Dalit theology essay; a recap of the praxis model.

Lecture 27. Theology in the mother tongue (The anthropological and synthetic models) Focus: Indian and inculturation theology; the triple dialogue with cultures, religions, and the poor; *jnana*, *bhakti*, *karma*; de Nobili and the contemplative model. Reading: Amaladoss, an essay from *Theologizing in India*; a recap of the anthropological and synthetic models.

Lecture 28. Whose voice was missing? (Feminist theology, the countercultural turn) Focus: the recovery of the erased; what changes when we speak of God in more than male terms; theology from the standpoint of women. Reading: Ormerod, the Elizabeth Johnson portrait, pages 185 to 194.

Lecture 29. Theology on the knees (Orthodox theology) Focus: the apophatic and liturgical tradition; theology as worship and mystery; "if you pray truly, you are a theologian." Reading: Ormerod, the John Meyendorff portrait, pages 205 to 214; Evagrius, *On Prayer*, opening.

UNIT VI — DOING THEOLOGY TODAY

Lectures 30 to 35. Goal served: How do I become a responsible theologian? Precept: be responsible.

The destination. The course gathers everything toward the responsible theologian, tested on the questions of our own moment, and ends with each student declaring his own theological identity.

Lecture 30. Can AI do theology? Focus: a machine can arrange words about God but cannot pray, believe, stand with the poor, or have the Abba experience; what theology truly requires. Reading: *Antiqua et Nova*, selected sections.

Lecture 31. Can the Church think together? (Synodality) Focus: synodality as a way of doing theology together; walking, listening, the apostolate of the ear; authority joined to responsibility. Reading: a short reading on synodality, for example from the 2024 Synod Final Document.

Lecture 32. Is the earth a theological text? (Ecology) Focus: creation as sacrament; the cry of the earth bound to the cry of the poor; finding God in all things. Reading: *Laudato Si'*, sections 1 to 16.

Lecture 33. How do faiths theologize together? (Dialogue and pluralism) Focus: God greater than every religion; dialogue in solidarity; pluralism in India as a reality to be lived. Reading: Amaladoss on interreligious dialogue, from *Theologizing in India*.

Lecture 34. What makes a theologian responsible today? Focus: the responsible theologian holds obedience and prophecy together, follows the four precepts, and counts

the cost; the whole course arrives here. Reading: *Donum Veritatis*, sections 24 to 41; a recap of the four precepts. In class: the debate, "Obedience or prophecy?", feeds participation.

Lecture 35. My Theology Manifesto Focus: each student presents a five-minute manifesto answering the six questions and declaring the kind of responsible theologian he commits to becoming, followed by a short question round; a blessing closes the course. Reading: none; review the journal and the glossary; write the manifesto.

ASSESSMENT MILESTONES ACROSS THE OUTLINE

Point in the course	Milestone	Weight
Daily	Theological journal	20%
Weekly	Cumulative glossary	10%
After Lecture 5	Unit I paper assigned (500 words)	folds into journal
Around Lecture 16	Parish-priest interview	10%
Around Lecture 21	Theological autobiography	15%
Around Lectures 25 and 33	Research paper, draft then final	20%
Lecture 35	Theology Manifesto, written and oral	15%
Throughout	Participation (rotation, debates, treasure hunts)	10%

No sit-down examination. The Manifesto, with its question round, is the capstone and safeguards the vocabulary. The scheme runs at roughly two to two and a half ECTS; to reach exactly two, drop either the autobiography or the interview and add its weight to the journal.

THE LIBRARY TREASURE HUNTS, SPACED ACROSS THE TERM

Three definitions of theology with sources; the earliest use of the word *theologia*; one real disagreement between Rahner and Ratzinger; five Indian theologians; three Orthodox theologians; one woman theologian; one African theologian. By the end, every student has met voices the standard lists leave out.

THE OUTLINE IN ONE LINE PER UNIT

Unit I asks why we do theology and ends by calling it a vocation. Unit II asks what theology is and where the line of authentic theology runs. Unit III asks who holds authority among the sources. Unit IV asks what question each age of history was answering. Unit V, the

heart, asks how theology is done and teaches the six models. Unit VI asks how to become a responsible theologian today and ends with the Manifesto. Across all six, the four precepts of Lonergan carry the student from attentiveness to responsibility, which is the whole point.

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